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Website <https://u3aepsom.nz/>.

MEETING PLACE

Royal Oak Bowls, 146 Selwyn St, Onehunga

10am on the 2ND Thursday of most months

NEWSLETTER

2026

Next meeting

10-12noon

Thursday 11 June 2026

Over the past three months the committee has looked closely at what we do, how we organise ourselves and our range of interest groups. We've also been in touch with other U3A chapters, and have investigated the scope and variety of interest groups that they operate. In short, we have conducted a self-audit of our activities.

We have also considered the response from you, our members, to suggestions whether or not we should make any substantive change to what we do. The overwhelming consensus is that we should not. Our membership would seem to be satisfied with the status quo.

It is hard not to agree with this conclusion. Our society appears to be functioning well, our meetings are well-attended, and our interest groups are well-patronised. Currently, we have twenty-seven of them; they span a wide range of activity and have broad appeal.

Thank you for your input to this discussion. It's a good thing, from time to time, to look critically at what we do and evaluate ourselves. We will, of course, continue to be on the lookout for different and innovative topics for new interest groups, and all ideas and suggestions towards that end are most welcome.

Take good care of yourselves - Winter's here.

Ian Jost

THOUGHT FOR THE MONTH

Do not complain because roses have thorns.
Be thankful that thorns have roses.

EPSOM U3A EXECUTIVE

President

Ian Jost – 027 488 7037
president.u3aepsom@gmail.com

Immediate Past President:

Duncan MacDonald – 021 316 661

General Duties

Kaye Buchanan- 021 299 0709

Secretary

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secretary.u3aepsom@gmail.com.

Minutes Secretary

Jeanette Saunders – 624 5025

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Thomas Tam - 520 1084
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Treasurer & Technical Officer

Thomas Tam - 520 1084
treasurer.u3aepsom@gmail.com

Almoner

Charmaine Strang – 027 4177 556

Interest Group Co-ordinators

Joslyn Squire – 021 168 0680

Bill Hagan – 021 611 247

Guest Speaker Organiser:

Ian Jost – 027 488 7037

Legal Advisor

Mike Matson – 022 630 7968

Newsletter

Jeanette Grant – 638 8566

Greeters:

Don Buchanan – 0275 928 131

Ngaira Mune – 624 0226

INTEREST GROUP CONVENERS

Applied Sciences

Peter Parsons - 021 521446

Attending Performing Arts

Shirin Caldwell – 630 1662

Architecture

Brian Murray – 021 026 68396

Art Appreciation

Kaye Buchanan – 021 299 0709

Art History

Emily Flynn – 021 0902 5094

Big History

Emily Flynn – 021 0902 5094

Book Chat

Helen Holdem - 021 260 3510

Chess Group

John Locke - 021-187 8061

Comparative Religions

Duncan MacDonald - 021-316 661

John Locke- 021-187 8061

Current Affairs

Shirley McConville – 622 3542

Fabric & Fibre Crafts

Charmaine Strang – 027-4177 556

Famous & Infamous Group

Shirley McConville – 622 3542

Foodies

Graham Gunn – 027 445 0929.

Garden Appreciation

Betty Townley - 626 6673

Introduction to Family History

Bryn Smith – 027 280 5235

Latin

Phyllis Downes – 630 5867

Lunch Bunch

Shirley McConville – 622 3542.

Music Appreciation

Carleen Edwards – 624 6298

History & Social Change

Helen Holdem – 021 260 3510

NZ History

Kaye Buchanan - 021 299 0709

Philosophy

Jocelyn Hewin - 634-1552

Scrabble

Joslyn Squire – 021 168 0680

Te Reo Maori

Jenny Whatman – 027 353 2487

Travel

Diana Hart- 021 284 4402

Walkers & Talkers Group

Don Buchanan- 0275 928 131

MAY SPEAKER'S REPORT	This month, we were treated to a very informative talk from Jen Calius, a Donor Co-ordinator Nurse Specialist for Organ Donation NZ, which is part of the NZ Blood Service. This organisation works closely with intensive care units and operating theatres in Australasia, to facilitate organ and tissue donation and to support donor families through the process. Jen works with a team of around 20 people. Their guiding principles include consideration of equity, ethics, tikanga, the law, and respect for donors and families, many of whom may have been exposed to tragic circumstances. Organ donors need to have died in an intensive care unit and have been on ventilation so the donor material is viable, as it deteriorates quickly, but tissue donors can be from hospital, the community and can be referred after death. Cancer is not a barrier, though blood and tissue testing is done before transplantation. 60-70 donations per year are done in NZ, after brain death, or more recently, after assisted death. If an organ is found to be unsuitable it is replaced in the body for burial or cremation. There are 25 donor hospitals in NZ, though the organs are sent to Auckland, Wellington or Christchurch with neurological or intensive care centres. We have a reciprocal agreement with Australia, as with a bigger population, rare tissue and blood types are more likely to be catered for. Category 1 recipients have first priority, and organs must be the right type and size for the recipient. We have an eye tissue bank in the Auckland Medical School which can take donor tissue from people 10-85 years of age. 83 people received eye tissue donations last year, including corneas and sclera (the white of the eye), which is used to improve the look of patients with artificial eyes. 25 people received heart valves, which are harvested from newborns or people aged up to 70 years. Donors also offer skin for burn victims, agreeing to this before death. Some countries have changed to an "opt out" system to enlarge the pool of available transplant material. Though many NZ people include their willingness to donate on their driver's licenses or in their wills, it is important to inform families and GPs of their wishes, as the bodily material has to be harvested rapidly after death to be viable. Intensive care staff will usually suggest donation of organs or tissue to families who have a loved one near death or having just died. If the deceased had suffered from blood cancers, melanoma, HIV, or Syphilis, this rules out the possibility of donation, so all donors have to be assessed for age and health status. It is still possible to donate corneas if the deceased has worn glasses or had another form of cancer. Written consent must be given for each donation and this is negotiated with the families of the deceased person. Families usually follow through on what the deceased person wanted, so it is important to communicate your wishes to the executors of your will. Donors and recipients usually remain anonymous to each other. For further information view the website: www.donor.co.nz <i>Joslyn Squire</i>
MEMBERSHIP	Our current membership number is 196
MAIN SPEAKER	Our speaker for the June meeting is John Locke, an Epsom U3A member since 2014. John has run several history interest groups. He will discuss the marriage of Henry VIII and Anne Boleyn, arguably one the most famous and tragic royal marriages in English history. John has studied the Tudors (one of the best known English royal dynasties) and the English Reformation extensively as part of his degree. While he doesn't claim to be an academic historian, he has an ongoing fascination with the dramatic events that unfolded in the Tudor period. Modern TV productions such as the 'Wolf Hall' trilogy (based on Hilary Mantel's Booker Award-winning books), and countless books and films have brought the Tudors vividly to life. John continues that tradition.

INTEREST GROUPS	[1] The Stories of the Past group will be starting again this month – 1.30pm on the 3rd Wednesday of the month – i.e. June 17 – at 662a Mt Eden Rd, Mt Eden, a villa up a R.O.W. which is also accessible from 13 Kakariki Ave. The Convenor will be Jeanette Grant – ph 638 8566. If you have not already indicated interest with Bill Hagan, please do so ASAP as spaces are limited. [2] Art History: Art History is a newish group and welcomes anyone to revel in an up-close look at great art starting with 13th century Giotto. This is intended to be an absolutely stress-free get together with no preparation or presentation required. The format is that we watch a delightful half-hour lecture featuring the great artists, pause for a long coffee break with lots of catching up, followed by a second erudite lecture on screen. In May, Caravaggio was featured and someone in the group let us know that a Festival film currently showing was about finding a 'lost' Caravaggio. Quite a few of us saw it at various theatres before the meeting. We like our long coffee breaks, and the expectation is that people will take turns on a roster bringing snacks (two people each meeting). Emily Flynn, Convenor
Re BLISTER PACKS	Unfortunately, I will not be collecting medical blister packs due to the rising costs of disposal for The Friends Of The Farm at Mangere. However, if you live at Mangere Bridge the library there will accept them for you. Charmaine Strang
2026 MEETING DATES Thursdays, 10am	11 June 9 July 13 August 10 September 8 October 12 November AGM NB Always wear your name badge and be seated ready at 10am

JEANETTE'S JOTTINGS

GOPHERS GROW GREEN

A short-lived experiment in the wake of the Mount St. Helens eruption has produced effects still visible 43 years later. By placing tiny creatures on barren volcanic ground, scientists unintentionally triggered a long-lasting recovery driven by underground life.

In May 1980, this eruption caused widespread destruction, leaving large areas covered in sterile pumice. Plant life struggled to return, and early signs of recovery were minimal, with only a handful of species managing to grow in the harsh conditions. Faced with this slow regeneration, researchers tested an unusual method. In 1983, they introduced pocket gophers to specific plots, hoping their burrowing would bring buried microorganisms back to the surface.

At first, there wasn't much to see. Before the experiment, only about a dozen plants had been recorded in the area. But things changed quickly. Six years later, the gopher-treated plots were filled with more than 40,000 plants, while nearby areas that didn't get the same treatment were still mostly barren.

What the subterranean creatures brought up wasn't just dirt. It included bacteria and mycorrhizal fungi: tiny organisms that play a big role in helping plants survive.

PLUG-IN SOLAR PANELS

A recent analysis from SolarPower Europe found that harnessing sunlight for energy has saved the continent more than €100 million per day since 1 March by lowering the demand for imported gas. This means Europe saved €3 billion last month alone.

Germany has been riding the plug-in solar wave long before the US-Israel war on Iran began, with more than one million systems installed between 2022 and 2025.

Commonly found in areas like balconies, terraces and shed roofs, plug-in solar uses small panels that can be attached to an external wall. In many European countries, these can be purchased from the supermarket or online. The power generated from plug-in solar can be used directly through a mains socket like any other device (such as a mobile phone charger) without any installation costs.

They're often seen as a great alternative for people living in rented or shared accommodation, where building rooftop solar panels isn't permitted.

Experts say it takes an average of two to six years to recoup the cost of the system, depending on what you paid for it, its size and where it is positioned. But once up and running, plug-in solar reduces the amount of electricity taken from the grid, cutting your energy bills.

The UK is the latest European country to lift restrictions on plug-in solar, recently announcing it is "driving forward" with a rollout of low-cost panels that will soon be available from budget retailers like Lidl and Iceland.

The Iran war has once again shown our drive for clean power is essential for our energy security so we can escape the grip of fossil fuel markets we don't control. WHETHER fitted as standard on new homes or making it possible for people to purchase plug-in solar in shops, we're determined to roll out clean power so we can give our country energy sovereignty." **WHY AREN'T WE DOING THIS?**

GREY HAIR FIGHTS CANCER!

A new study from the University of Tokyo suggests going gray could actually mean your body is protecting itself from cancer. Lead researcher Yasuaki Mohri told Newsweek, "*Hair graying may be a sign that McSCs (Melanocyte stem cells) exceeding a certain threshold have been eliminated, protecting the skin from cancer risk.*" McSCs are the stem cells responsible for hair and skin pigmentation. Deep inside each hair follicle are pigment-making stem cells. When their DNA gets damaged – by sun, stress, or just life – they sometimes shut down colour production as a form of self-defence. The researchers used mice to see how these particular stem cells in the hair follicles react to different kinds of DNA damage. They discovered that when they see dangerous DNA double-strand breaks, linked to cancers, especially melanoma, they activate a process that ends up killing them off. If these cells detect too much DNA damage, they activate a "self-destruct" mode. The bad cells activate a process to die off instead of multiplying. Basically, your body sacrifices that lovely hair colour to keep you safe. But sometimes, under UV light or toxic chemicals, this shutdown doesn't happen properly. Mohri told Newsweek, "*Under a carcinogenic environment, however, this process is suppressed, resulting in the retention of severely damaged cells that pose a risk within the tissue.*" If those damaged cells hang around instead of dying off, they start cloning themselves. That's when tissues can become more vulnerable to skin cancers like melanoma. Co-author Emi Nishimura said in a statement: "*The same stem cell population can follow antagonistic fates – exhaustion or expansion – depending on the type of stress.*" Translation: sometimes your hair goes gray; other times, your cells go rogue. Most people start seeing grays in their thirties or forties, depending on their background (for Caucasians, average is mid-thirties, late thirties for Asians and mid-forties for Black people). But only about 6 to 23 percent of people between 45 and 65 have mostly gray hair. The study doesn't say gray hair prevents cancer directly, but it reframes it as a visible side effect of your cells doing damage control. Going gray might not be viewed as glamorous, but it is a sign your body's still got your back. So next time you see a gray, you can thank it for not taking any chances.

A NAVIGATION HAZARD HIDDEN IN PLAIN SIGHT

A German research vessel seeking shelter from rough weather has discovered a previously unknown island in a remote and poorly charted corner of Antarctica. The rocky outcrop, measuring 130 meters long and 50 meters wide, was encountered in February 2026 as the icebreaker navigated a region of the northwestern Weddell Sea historically marked on nautical charts as an "unexplored danger zone."

The island was not visible on satellite imagery used for navigation planning. It appeared initially as a dirty iceberg before closer inspection confirmed exposed bedrock. The feature will soon receive an official name and be added to international nautical charts for the first time.

The ship's multibeam echo sounder and an onboard drone measured the island precisely. Dimensions: 130 meters long, 50 meters wide, and 16 meters high. For reference, the 'Polarstern' itself measures 118 meters from bow to stern, making the island only slightly longer than the ship that found it. The total surface area is roughly 6,200 square meters.

Why had it not been mapped before?

First, the island is covered in ice and snow, rendering it nearly indistinguishable from the countless icebergs that drift through the Weddell Sea. Satellite images show a white speck amid a vast field of white specks. The ice cap atop the bedrock blends seamlessly with surrounding sea ice during winter and with calved glacial fragments during summer.

Second, the region has been deliberately avoided by mariners for generations. Nautical charts designated the area as an "unexplored danger zone" based on incomplete or unverified data

TURNING WASTE INTO CLEAN FUEL

According to Our World in Data, plastic production now reaches 450 million tonnes per year, a staggering increase since 1950, when only 2 million tonnes were produced. The bulk of that plastic winds up in landfills (and about 0.5% lands in our oceans) after it is used, with only about 18% getting recycled and another 24% handled by incineration. That means finding a way to deal with plastic waste is of critical importance.

Current mechanical recycling methods can handle large amounts of plastics, but they have their issues. Contamination from food and other materials can foul large batches of potentially recyclable plastics. Also, new plastic produced this way is often inferior to the original product, so the process really results in downcycling more than recycling or upcycling.

Chemical recycling methods are much more effective, especially when a photocatalyst is used to alter the constituent building blocks of plastics using light. But to reach that point, acids are often used to initially break down the plastic, and most photocatalysts can't stand up to the harsh environment created by these acids.

However, the Cambridge study showed a path forward that makes use of both acids and photocatalysts. *The discovery was almost accidental,*" says Cambridge's Erwin Reisner, who led the research. *"We used to think acid was completely off limits in these solar-powered systems, because it would simply dissolve everything. But our catalyst developed didn't – and suddenly a whole new world of reactions opened up."*

As a first step inside the new reactor, plastics are broken down using sulphuric acid through a process known as hydrolysis. In this case, the acid came from discarded car batteries. When applied to the plastics, the long molecular chains from which they were made are snipped apart at their chemical joints...

Once introduced to the liquid acid mixture, simply exposing the system to sunlight (well, an LED-simulated equivalent, anyway) allowed it to convert the ethylene glycol molecules into hydrogen and acetic acid, the main component of vinegar.

In testing, the team reports the reactor generated "high hydrogen yields" and ran for 260 hours without any loss in performance.

Because the catalyst doesn't use any precious metals, as is often the case with such chemicals, it is affordable and scalable. But most critically, it was able to do its job even in the presence of the harsh acid from the discarded car batteries, which are 20-40% acid by volume. That acid usually has to be neutralized before the batteries can be properly disposed of, which is a resource-heavy procedure.

A MASSIVE UNDERWATER DUMPING SITE

There was a period between the 1930s and the early 1970s, when different kinds of waste were routinely dumped offshore. Data from the U.S. Environmental Protection Agency show that this included chemical waste, oil-drilling byproducts, as well as radioactive materials and military explosives, spread across 14 disposal sites.

The scale of the problem only really came into public view recently. In 2020, an investigation by the Los Angeles Times revealed that deep-sea surveys had uncovered large numbers of barrels scattered across the ocean floor. Follow-up missions by the Scripps Institution of Oceanography later identified around 27,000 barrel-like objects and more than 100,000 pieces of debris...

Even after more than 50 years, the waste is still affecting its surroundings... There are still a lot of unknowns, especially when it comes to how many barrels are down there and what exactly they contain, so scientists are only starting to grasp the full extent of the problem.

WHY HAS THE GREAT PYRAMID OF GIZA SURVIVED?

The Great Pyramid of Giza in Egypt has survived for more than 4,500 years. Earthquakes have repeatedly shaken the region, including the magnitude 5.8 Cairo earthquake in 1992, which dislodged some of the pyramid's outer casing stones. Yet the main body remained essentially intact.

A new study of the pyramid's vibrations by Egyptian geophysicist Asem Salama and colleagues provides insight into its performance during earthquakes and identifies some interesting features. The pyramid may not have been intentionally designed for resilience in an earthquake. But its survival is not an accident, either...

The researchers measured the pyramid's vibrations in ambient conditions. They found that its natural frequencies – the frequencies at which it "prefers" to vibrate – are mostly between about 2.0 and 2.6 hertz (cycles per second). The surrounding soil has a much lower dominant frequency, around 0.6Hz.

Every structure has a natural rhythm... If earthquake shaking matches a structure's natural frequency, the motion can be amplified. This is called resonance, and it can be catastrophic

From an engineering point of view, it has many favourable features: a broad base, low centre of mass, tapering form, symmetrical plan, competent limestone foundation, and massive masonry load path. It is squat, stiff, and well-founded rather than tall, slender, and flexible... the builders made excellent empirical

engineering choices which may have been driven by construction experience, observation, structural necessity, or cultural intent. Their seismic benefits may be real without being the original purpose.

The Great Pyramid's survival is not magic. Nor is it proof of ancient seismic design.

**Invitation
from the Network Committee
to every member in u3a!**

**Are you passionate about a particular subject or event?
Have you ever been approached in person about being a mini speaker for our
EVENT?**

**Do you know others in your group who are?
Have you ever approached them about becoming a mini speaker for our
EVENT?**

It might be May '26 but it is not too late to be considered!

Here is what you need to do:-

- prepare a 12 minute presentation using PowerPoint OR encourage/persuade your member(s) to prepare one
- practise, practise and practise! Know your material thoroughly!
 - ensure that you can use a microphone successfully
 - present talk to your u3a group
- if you are nominated by your group to be a mini speaker, the next step is:-
 - present your talk to the Network Committee via Zoom or Google Meet

**The mini speaker part of our EVENT is integral to all that u3a stands for
and believes in - ongoing learning by researching and sharing the
knowledge gained**

**From now on, the Network Committee is calling for your nominations for this
year's EVENT.**

Together, we can do this!

Network Committee 2026